

Publication details

Animal Health Committee (AHC) provides national leadership and technical expertise on Australian animal health and biosecurity matters. AHC includes the Australian, state and territory chief veterinary officers, and the Australian Centre for Disease Preparedness; with Animal Health Australia, Wildlife Health Australia and New Zealand Ministry for Primary Industries as observers. The Committee reports to the National Biosecurity Committee. AHC met for its second face-to-face (F2F) meeting of 2025 in Brisbane on 21-23 October 2025 (AHC48). The next AHC F2F meeting will be held in March 2026 in the Northern Territory.

AHC strategic priorities

AHC discussed strategic priorities for its 2026 workplan and alignment with the strategic risks identified by the National Biosecurity Committee. Key activities were identified to improve Australia's preparedness and response capacity for emergency animal diseases (EAD) and to improve Australia's animal health surveillance, diagnostic and data capabilities, and an assessment of emerging strategic issues in animal health. In the face of increasing global pressures, the Committee agreed to include horizon scanning in its future planning processes to ensure a proactive approach to managing animal health in Australia.

Improving effectiveness of EAD responses

AHC discussed challenges and opportunities to improve the effectiveness of EAD responses, informed by learnings from recent high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) responses. AHC agreed to prioritise work to explore opportunities for more scalable and cost-effective responses through greater government-industry collaboration.

HPAI preparedness

AHC acknowledged the dynamic and evolving global H5 HPAI situation and the value of Australia's proactive efforts to strengthen its national preparedness and response capability. To contribute to preparedness efforts, AHC discussed progress with its review of the vaccination policy for poultry and next steps with vaccination research pilots for rare, protected and valuable birds. AHC also committed to ongoing stakeholder engagement to ensure that any future H5 HPAI response is fully informed by livestock, veterinary, wildlife, and One Health perspectives.

National lumpy skin disease (LSD) Action Plan

AHC discussed progress on its activities under the [National LSD Action Plan](#), which includes developing national surveillance and vaccination strategies. The findings of a literature review on overseas

experiences with the use of vaccination to control LSD was presented to AHC, which will inform the development of the vaccination policy.

Antimicrobial resistance (AMR)

AHC's AMR Task Group reported on activities in [Australia's Antimicrobial Resistance Animal Sector Action Plan 2023-28](#), requiring government leadership including communications, surveillance, and reporting. AHC recognised the importance of this work and committed to promote clear and decisive action in response to national and international AMR trends. AHC agreed to support the AMR Task Group to continue for a further 12 months.

One Health Forum

The Queensland Department of Primary Industries hosted a One Health Forum with Queensland Government partners and Wildlife Health Australia. The Forum focussed on the Queensland government's holistic One Health approach to HPAI preparedness and included discussions on preparedness activities, governance, enhanced surveillance, environmental protections, robust biosecurity measures, and safeguarding public health and worker safety through collaboration and communication efforts.

Stakeholder session

AHC was joined by 16 stakeholders for its open stakeholder session. Key topics discussed included the roles and challenges of private veterinarians (including wildlife specialists) during EAD responses, enhancing on-farm biosecurity standards, and how best to harness the strengths of industry and governments during EAD responses.

Acknowledgements

AHC would like to thank the Queensland Department of Primary Industries and Australia Zoo for hosting the AHC48 meeting. AHC also thanks its industry stakeholders for attending the stakeholder session and sharing their knowledge and experience.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/health/committees/communique/oct-2025>